

PARTICIPANT HANDOUT

Christian Nationalism: An 8-Week Study

Small groups, adult Sunday school, and individuals.

SESSION 1

What It Is and What It Is Not

A man left Bell's office certain his pastor had insulted his grandfather, who landed at Normandy. He had not. The phrase Christian nationalism has been ruined in both directions, used as a slur against patriotic faith by some and as a catchall for people I disagree with who pray by others. Between those two distortions the real thing has nearly disappeared. Bell makes the strongest case for the man who fears the phrase before answering it. Loving your country is not a sin. Scripture tells exiles to seek the welfare of Babylon. But the scholars who coined the careful term, Whitehead and Perry, defined it as a cultural framework that fuses American civic identity with Christian identity, holds the nation has a covenant with God, and believes the kingdom of Christ can be advanced by capturing the state. The key word is fuses. Patriotism loves a country and can repent. Nationalism has made the nation the thing that judges, so it cannot. The covenant many assume is ancient was legislated in living memory, one nation under God added in 1954, in God we trust in 1956.

KEY SCRIPTURE

John 18:36

REFLECT

1. Where did I first learn to fuse my faith and my country, and did anyone ever teach it to me on purpose, or was it just in the air I breathed?

Notes

2. What would it cost me to admit my country could be wrong about a thing I care about, and why does that cost feel so high?

Notes

3. If Christ and my country commanded different things tomorrow, do I actually know which one I would obey, or have I arranged my life so the question never comes up?

Notes

THIS WEEK, TRY THIS

This week, notice once when you feel a stronger reaction to an insult against your country than to an insult against Christ. Do not fix it. Just notice the temperature, and write down what it told you.

SESSION 2

Loving Versus Worshiping Your Country

Bell's oldest son asked, after a parade, why we put our hands over our hearts. The honest answer is that we make the same gesture in two settings, before the flag and when we pray, and a child notices the rhyme an adult has stopped hearing. Love and worship are not opposites. Worship is what love becomes when it stops admitting any limit. Bell defends the love before warning against the worship, because the warning is dishonest without the defense. A Christian may love his country truly. Scripture told exiles to love Babylon. But the line is plain. Love can be corrected and worship cannot, because correction assumes a standard above the thing and worship has put the thing where no standard reaches it. The test is not how you feel at the parade. It is what you do when your country is wrong. Niebuhr called nationalism the point where patriotism becomes demonic, claiming the unconditioned loyalty that belongs to God alone. Augustine called sin disordered love, the lesser good loved as though it were the greatest. The problem was never the size of the love. It was the place the love was put.

KEY SCRIPTURE

1 Samuel 8:7

REFLECT

1. What do I defend most fiercely, and what does that reveal about what I actually worship?

Notes

2. Can I name a single time I have let my country be wrong out loud, and if not, what does that silence tell me?

Notes

3. Where in my life is a good love sitting in the wrong order, above something or someone it should serve rather than rule?

Notes

THIS WEEK, TRY THIS

This week, find one specific way your country has been wrong about something, name it out loud to one person, and notice whether your love survives the correction. If it does, that is the love God permits. If it cannot, that is the worship he forbids.

SESSION 3

Flags in the Sanctuary

Two flags stand on the platform of the church where Bell learned to preach. He did not put them there, and neither did the pastors before him. They simply appeared in the middle of the last century, without a vote, and now to move them would feel like aggression while placing them would have felt like nothing. That asymmetry is the whole subject. We defend to the point of fury an arrangement we never chose to make. Bell makes the honest case for the flag first. It can be gratitude, an honor to those who served and did not come home, a recognition that the church lives in a real country. He grants that removal can be a sneer rather than a confession, performed pride rather than worship. Then he answers with a question about geography. Not the lobby, where we might thank God for a free country, but the platform, beside the pulpit, inside the jealous space the architecture reserves for Word and table and baptism. Placement is a sermon. Bellah showed civil religion is a real religion with sacred objects. Carry a sacred object from one faith into the holy space of another and you do not get nothing. You get fusion. Bell confesses he has not moved his own flags, because he knows what it would cost.

KEY SCRIPTURE

1 Kings 8:11

REFLECT

1. What stands in the place of honor in the spaces where I worship, and what has it been teaching me without my consent?

Notes

2. Where am I the priest who has grown used to a second altar rather than the one willing to pay the cost of moving it?

Notes

3. What am I unwilling to examine because examining it would cost me something with the people around me?

Notes

THIS WEEK, TRY THIS

This week, walk through your own church or your own home and read the room like a sermon. What stands in the place of honor, and what is it quietly teaching the children who grow up looking at it? Just observe. Bring what you notice back next time.

SESSION 4

Whose Kingdom? Jesus and Political Power

Before Jesus preached or healed, he was taken to a high place and shown every kingdom of the world by one who actually had them to give. The price was a single act of worship aimed in the wrong direction. Jesus refused, and the refusal is the founding decision of his ministry. He would not take the kingdoms of the world on the terms by which they are taken. We reopen this every election as though he never settled it. Bell gives the strongest objection a full hearing. The prophets confronted kings, John the Baptist lost his head, Wilberforce ended a slave trade, Bonhoeffer joined a plot against Hitler. A church that washes its hands of power has often washed its hands of the people power crushes. Bell grants the whole of it. The error he warns against is not engagement but the belief that engagement means seizing the throne, that Christ needs to govern through Caesar because he cannot govern otherwise. The difference between Wilberforce and Christian nationalism is the difference between salt and a coup. To Pilate, Jesus said his kingdom is not of this world, and the proof he offered was the absence of fighting. On the cross he took the throne by the one means no empire understands. He did not seize power. He absorbed it.

KEY SCRIPTURE

Matthew 4:8-10

REFLECT

1. Where did my hope actually go the last time the returns came in, and what does that reveal about which kingdom I serve?

Notes

2. Do I believe the gospel can accomplish anything without political victory, or have I quietly decided it needs Caesar's sword?

Notes

3. What is the difference, in my own life, between being salt and attempting a coup, and which one have I been practicing?

Notes

THIS WEEK, TRY THIS

This week, when you feel the pull to believe a political victory would finally fix things, pray one sentence instead, your kingdom come, your will be done, and notice how it reorders where your hope is sitting.

SESSION 5

How the Religious Right Was Built

A young pastor who shadowed Bell assumed the religious right had always existed, that faithfulness had always come with a voter guide attached. Bell had to tell him the movement he took for the weather was younger than Bell's parents, built on purpose by people whose names we know in years we can count. It is not the ancient form of Christian political engagement but a specific coalition constructed in the 1970s around specific grievances. Bell grants the strongest defense first. Christians were not wrong to enter politics, the unborn are owed protection, a faith with no public voice has surrendered something. But the honest history complicates the founding story. The popular account says the movement rose in response to Roe in 1973. Randall Balmer argues, as one influential and contested reading, that in the years right after Roe white evangelical leaders were notably quiet about abortion, and that the fire that organized the movement was lit over the defense of segregated religious schools against federal interference. Bell is careful to say this is a contested thesis, not a closed verdict, and that the cleanest segregation-not-abortion story is too tidy for the evidence. What is fair to say is narrower and still uncomfortable. Race was woven into the movement's origins far more deeply than its founding myth admits. A thing built by men in years we can count can also, by grace, be examined and rebuilt.

KEY SCRIPTURE

Matthew 4:8-10

REFLECT

1. What political conviction have I held as a soldier rather than as a Christian, and could I still be corrected on it?

Notes

2. Where was I handed a construction and told it was the ancient faith, and have I ever stopped to learn the date it was built?

Notes

3. When have I preferred a powerful person who served my side over a faithful one who did not, and what did that preference reveal?

Notes

THIS WEEK, TRY THIS

This week, trace one political conviction you hold back to where you first received it. Ask whether you hold it as a Christian or as a soldier, and whether you could still be corrected on it. Write down what you find.